CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

Issue 005 Tuesday, October 13, 2026 · Biweekly, 4 pages

Home Services

Pest Control · Septic & Sewer · Landscape · Pool · Appliance Repair · Moving

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

IN THIS ISSUE

PEST CONTROL
EPA's registration review schedule reflects a four-year extension of the deadline for final decisions to October 1, 2026, and EPA published a final decision for 4-CPA on September 28.

SEPTIC & SEWER
JDC and Vacuum Truck Rentals combined into Rentix Solutions, a rental platform with more than 36 locations, 3,200 vacuum, sewer and hydrovac units, and 300,000 parts SKUs, Pumper reported September 30.

LANDSCAPE
DR Power recalled about 42,860 Pilot and Premier walk-behind trimmer mowers on October 8 after 19 fires, because grass and debris can build up and ignite; the fix is a free repair kit.

POOL
PHTA opened applications October 9 for a committee to revise ANSI/PHTA/ICC-4, the aboveground pool standard, to update child-resistance requirements; applications close November 6.

APPLIANCE REPAIR
EPA and DOE finalized the ENERGY STAR transition plan August 28; DOE already leads the program (effective June 1), and specifications, certification bodies and product lists are not being rewritten in the handoff.

MOVING
FMCSA published notices October 6 and 7 for two 16-week hours-of-service studies of 256 drivers each, one letting drivers pause the 14-hour clock up to three hours at a pickup or delivery.

BACKGROUND SIGNAL
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

TRADE

Leslie's, the largest pool supply chain with more than 900 stores, filed Chapter 11 on September 30 to erase $685 million of debt, a day after closing about 76 stores.

Leslie's, Inc. and ten subsidiaries filed prearranged Chapter 11 cases on September 30 in Houston (Case No. 26-90795). The company says the plan eliminates about $685 million, or 90%, of funded debt. Lenders holding about 81.1% of term loan claims signed the restructuring support agreement. Existing common stock is cancelled for no consideration, lenders become majority owners, and Leslie's targets emergence in early 2027.

About 76 U.S. stores closed September 29 and are to be vacated within two weeks, after roughly 80 underperforming stores and a distribution center closed earlier this year. Leslie's still counts more than 900 locations. Fiscal third-quarter sales fell 8.4% to $458.5 million, comparable sales fell 6.2%, and gross margin dropped to 36.5% from 39.6%.

New money is a $90 million term loan DIP and $60 million of equity, both backstopped by lenders, plus a $225 million asset-based DIP facility from existing ABL lenders. Nasdaq trading was set to be suspended October 6, with shares moving to over-the-counter markets. First-day motions ask the court to let Leslie's pay wages, honor gift cards and loyalty benefits, and pay critical vendors in the ordinary course.

The schedule is fast. The plan and disclosure statement are due by October 20, a hearing on remaining first-day motions is October 27, the creditors' meeting is November 16, and confirmation is due by January 8, 2027. The DIP loans mature six months after the petition. None of the pages retrieved address independent pool pros directly; the exposure is as supplier, as customer, and as competitor for closed-store customers.

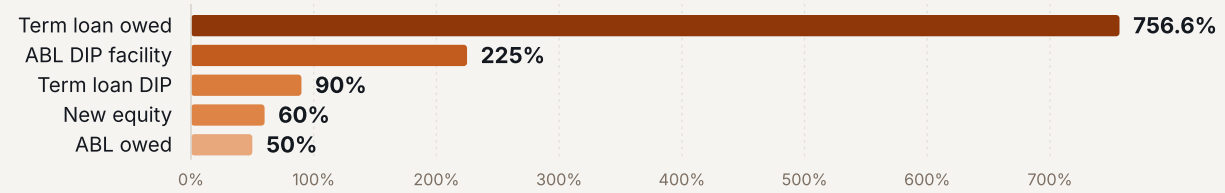
> **What to do about it:** Today, pull every open balance, credit, warranty claim and prepaid gift card you hold with Leslie's or any of the ten debtors, including Pool Parts, Horizon Spa & Pool Parts, Hot Tub Works and RAM Chemical & Supply, and stop prepaying or extending credit. If a debtor owes you for goods or work from before September 30, file a claim through the Kroll case site (Submit a Claim link) or call 844-408-3397; no claims bar date is posted yet. Line up a second source for chemicals and parts in writing, with prices held through winter. Ask customers which closed stores they used, and call them before a competitor does. Calendar October 27 and November 16.

Leslie's Chapter 11 case site (Kroll), No. 26-90795 · Leslie's Form 8-K, September 30, 2026 (SEC) · Pool Magazine: Leslie's results and Chapter 11 filing

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / LESLIE'S BALANCE SHEET

Leslie's term loan of about $757 million is more than three times the $225 million of DIP credit the court is asked to approve.

Debt and financing amounts, $ millions, from Leslie's Form 8-K dated September 30, 2026 (accelerated debt, DIP and equity terms); the $685 million, 90% reduction figure is from Pool Magazine



The plan is to eliminate about $685 million (about 90%) of funded debt, out of the roughly $757 million term loan and $50 million ABL owed. New money is a $225 million asset-based DIP line, a $90 million term DIP and $60 million of equity. Both DIP loans mature six months after the September 30 petition, and the DIP milestones require confirmation within 100 days (by January 8, 2027). Lenders become majority owners. Leslie's Form 8-K, September 30, 2026 (SEC)

PEST CONTROL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA's registration review schedule reflects a four-year extension of the deadline for final decisions to October 1, 2026, and EPA published a final decision for 4-CPA on September 28.

Why it matters: EPA's registration review schedule page (updated July 17) says the deadline for completing registration review final decisions is now October 1, 2026, reflecting the four-year extension, and aligns rodenticide and many insecticide schedules with its Endangered Species Act strategies. The September 28 notice (91 FR 61228) finalizes only 4-CPA. The page says EPA has completed final or interim decisions for all but 144 of the 726 total pesticide cases and announces no further extension, so label changes are still possible. Ask your distributor which rodenticide, pyrethroid and termiticide labels you use still await a final decision, and keep dated copies of current labels.

EPA: updated registration review schedule · Federal Register: 4-CPA final decision, Sept. 28, 2026

SUPPLY

Zoëcon is showing an expanded label for its 25(b)-exempt Essentria Mosquito & Tick concentrate, adding spiders, flies, fire ants, pharaoh ants and spotted lanternfly nymphs, at PestWorld 2026 in Grapevine, Texas.

Why it matters: PMP reported it September 25; it is a product announcement, not a rule. The concentrate uses geraniol, clove oil and cornmint oil and repels mosquitoes for up to 14 days; Essentria G granular returns with a new formula and size. No price, label date or state approval list was published. Ask your rep for the new label and price list (Zoëcon is at booth 607) and check your state's rules on 25(b) products before adding it to a service plan.

PMP: Zoëcon at PestWorld 2026, Sept. 25, 2026

SEPTIC & SEWER

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

JDC and Vacuum Truck Rentals combined into Rentix Solutions, a rental platform with more than 36 locations, 3,200 vacuum, sewer and hydrovac units, and 300,000 parts SKUs, Pumper reported September 30.

Why it matters: Terms were not disclosed, and the roundup does not say which markets overlap. Rentix reports more than 100 certified service bays. Exposed are pumpers, jetting and hydrovac operators who rent trucks or buy parts from either firm: one large lessor can mean fewer competing quotes where both operated. Before your next fall rental or truck repair, get a written rate and parts lead time from Rentix and one other lessor, and note the date of each quote.

Pumper: Industry News, October 2026

MONEY

Pumper's October editorial says some municipal treatment plants now test incoming septage for PFAS or reject loads, leaving haulers longer trips, fewer disposal sites and higher tipping fees.

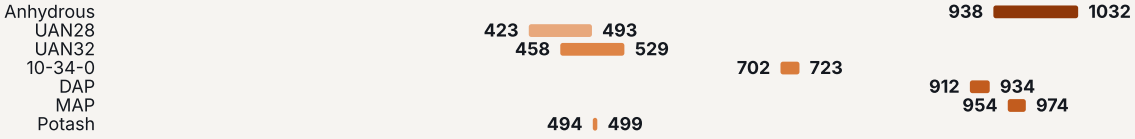
Why it matters: This is a September 30 trade-press editorial, not a rule, and it gives no fee amounts and names no states beyond saying several restrict spreading biosolids on farmland. Without land application, it says, contractors haul to specialized landfills or thermal facilities, which raises operating costs significantly. Call every plant you dump at, ask in writing whether it tests loads for PFAS and what triggers rejection, and get your next-closest approved site and its tipping fee on paper before a rejection strands a full truck.

Pumper: PFAS, regulations and the cost of waste disposal

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / FERTILIZER SWINGS

Anhydrous, UAN28 and UAN32 each swung $70 to $94 a ton across four readings since July, while phosphates and potash moved $22 or less.

Low and high of DTN weekly average retail prices, $ per ton, for Jul 6-10, Aug 3-7, Aug 31-Sep 4 and Sep 28-Oct 2, 2026; latest release October 7, 2026



Nitrogen carries the risk. Anhydrous opened July at $1,032 and sits at $979 after a low of $938; UAN28 fell from $493 to $423 before rebounding to $430. Phosphates and potash held a narrow band. For a lawn company, a full year of fixed-price fertilizer quoted off today's number is a bet. Ask suppliers for fall pre-buy terms and price in an escalator. DTN Retail Fertilizer Trends, Oct. 7, 2026

LANDSCAPE

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

DR Power recalled about 42,860 Pilot and Premier walk-behind trimmer mowers on October 8 after 19 fires, because grass and debris can build up and ignite; the fix is a free repair kit.

Why it matters: The recall covers all serial numbers of eight Pilot and Premier models sold from November 2022 through July 2026 for $380 to $550 at Ace, TSC, Bomgaars, independent power equipment dealers and drpower.com. CPSC lists two minor injuries, blisters. Check the model plate on every walk-behind trimmer mower in your fleet today, park matches, and request kits for all units at once so crews are not idled one machine at a time. Log the downtime. If you resell used equipment, federal law bars selling recalled units.

CPSC: DR Power trimmer mowers recall, Oct. 8, 2026

DEMAND

EPA announced more than $90 million on October 2 for 83 Chesapeake Bay watershed projects, $37 million from EPA and $53 million from other agencies, covering soil, barriers and habitat.

Why it matters: Grants run through two NFWF programs, Small Watershed Grants and Innovative Nutrient and Sediment Reduction, and go to farmers, homeowners, churches, businesses and municipalities. Since 1999 the programs have awarded over $800 million in more than 2,000 grants and treated runoff from over 23,000 acres of impervious surface. EPA's release gives no project budgets, bidding rules or eligibility terms. If you do stormwater, soil or planting work in the watershed, open the recipient lists EPA linked, find grantees near you, and call them about subcontract work before their projects go to bid.

EPA: Over $90 million for Chesapeake Bay, Oct. 2, 2026

POOL

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

PHTA opened applications October 9 for a committee to revise ANSI/PHTA/ICC-4, the aboveground pool standard, to update child-resistance requirements; applications close November 6.

Why it matters: The revision is limited to child-resistance requirements and runs about seven months under ANSI's periodic maintenance process; the call also ran in ANSI's Standards Action on October 9. PHTA does not say what will change, so no cost to owners can be stated yet. Manufacturers, producers, retailers, water safety advocates, regulators and consumers can apply; PHTA does not list installers. People who have used or enforced the 2025 standard get some priority. If you install or service aboveground pools, ask PHTA whether installers qualify, or apply as a retailer or consumer-side member, by November 6, and pull your current barrier and ladder practice so you can compare it with the draft.

PHTA: Revision of PHTA-4 standard, Oct. 9, 2026

REGULATION

CPSC warned September 17 that about 480 Lanyitongke drain covers sold on Amazon for about $9 violate the Virginia Graeme Baker Act, and the seller has not answered requests for a recall.

Why it matters: The white 7.87-inch covers, model SP1030-A, lack required markings, a stated service life and instructions; no injuries are reported. CPSC says remove, replace and dispose, and stop using pools with them until replaced. Check the markings on every drain cover on your routes and in your van stock, replace any unmarked cover, and note the date and model in each customer file.

CPSC warning: Lanyitongke drain covers, Sept. 17, 2026

APPLIANCE REPAIR

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

EPA and DOE finalized the ENERGY STAR transition plan August 28; DOE already leads the program (effective June 1), and specifications, certification bodies and product lists are not being rewritten in the handoff.

Why it matters: ServiceMag (Sept. 28) reports EPA keeps the trademark until a separate transfer plan, due September 1, sets a date; that date was not public. The website, Product Finder and Incentive Management Platform move to DOE, with the IT move expected before July 2027, so lookup URLs may change. The label's meaning and logo stay the same. If you pull qualifying model numbers for rebate paperwork, save dated copies now and confirm with each utility rebate program which lookup it accepts.

ServiceMag: ENERGY STAR moves to DOE, Sept. 28, 2026

DEMAND

Frontdoor's second-quarter claims costs fell $7 million even as contractors, parts and equipment cost low-single-digits more, across about 17,000 network contractors handling 3.8 million requests a year.

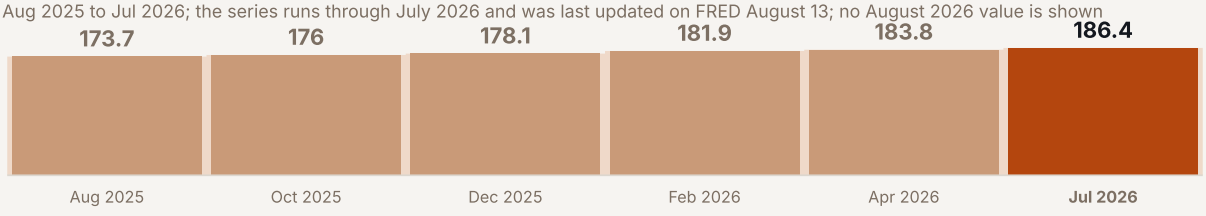
Why it matters: ServiceMag (Oct. 12) relays Frontdoor's August 6 results: revenue $645 million, up 5%; active warranties 2.11 million, up 1%; retention 79.6%. About $5 million of the claims savings was favorable weather. These are second-quarter numbers; the next report is due in early November. If you take warranty-network jobs, pull last quarter's tickets, compute margin after parts, and flag any parts line that rose since June before you accept the next fee schedule.

ServiceMag: Frontdoor Q2 2026 results, Oct. 12, 2026

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / REPAIR SERVICE PRICES

Producer prices for repair and maintenance services rose every month from August 2025 to July 2026, ending 7.3% higher.

BLS Producer Price Index, repair and maintenance services (partial), index Jun 2009=100, not seasonally adjusted; selected months Aug 2025 to Jul 2026; the series runs through July 2026 and was last updated on FRED August 13; no August 2026 value is shown



The index climbed from 173.7 in August 2025 to 186.4 in July 2026, a 7.3% rise, and fell in no month of the 12-month table. It tracks what repair and maintenance providers charge, so it is a yardstick for your own rate sheet. If your labor or trip charges have not moved in the past year, compare them with this. Months shown are every other month plus July, not the full series. BLS PPI via FRED: repair and maintenance services (WPU55)

MOVING

TWO ITEMS

LABOR

FMCSA published notices October 6 and 7 for two 16-week hours-of-service studies of 256 drivers each, one letting drivers pause the 14-hour clock up to three hours at a pickup or delivery.

Why it matters: The other study tests splitting sleeper berth time as 5/5 or 6/4. Comments on both are due December 7. Eligible carriers need interstate authority, no Unsatisfactory rating, no FMCSA enforcement action in three years, and out-of-service rates at or below the national average. The notices do not mention household goods carriers. If crews lose hours waiting at origins or destinations, file a comment with your wait-time data, and pull your own out-of-service rates now.

Federal Register: 14-hour pause pilot notice, Oct. 6 · Federal Register: sleeper split pilot notice, Oct. 7

REGULATION

FMCSA's October 5 final rule lengthens automatic hours-of-service relief after a regional emergency declaration from 14 days to 30 days, but only for trucks giving direct assistance to restore essential services.

Why it matters: Effective October 5 (49 CFR 390.23(b)), the relief covers hours-of-service rules 395.3 and 395.5 and does not suspend registration requirements. The rule does not mention household goods carriers. FMCSA expects 25 extension requests a year instead of 50. Petitions for reconsideration are due November 4. Treat routine storm-season relocations and storage runs as outside the relief unless a declaration or FMCSA says otherwise: keep logs as normal, and ask your state's emergency management office in writing before any disaster job.

Federal Register: emergency exemptions final rule, Oct. 5 · FMCSA press release, Oct. 5, 2026

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

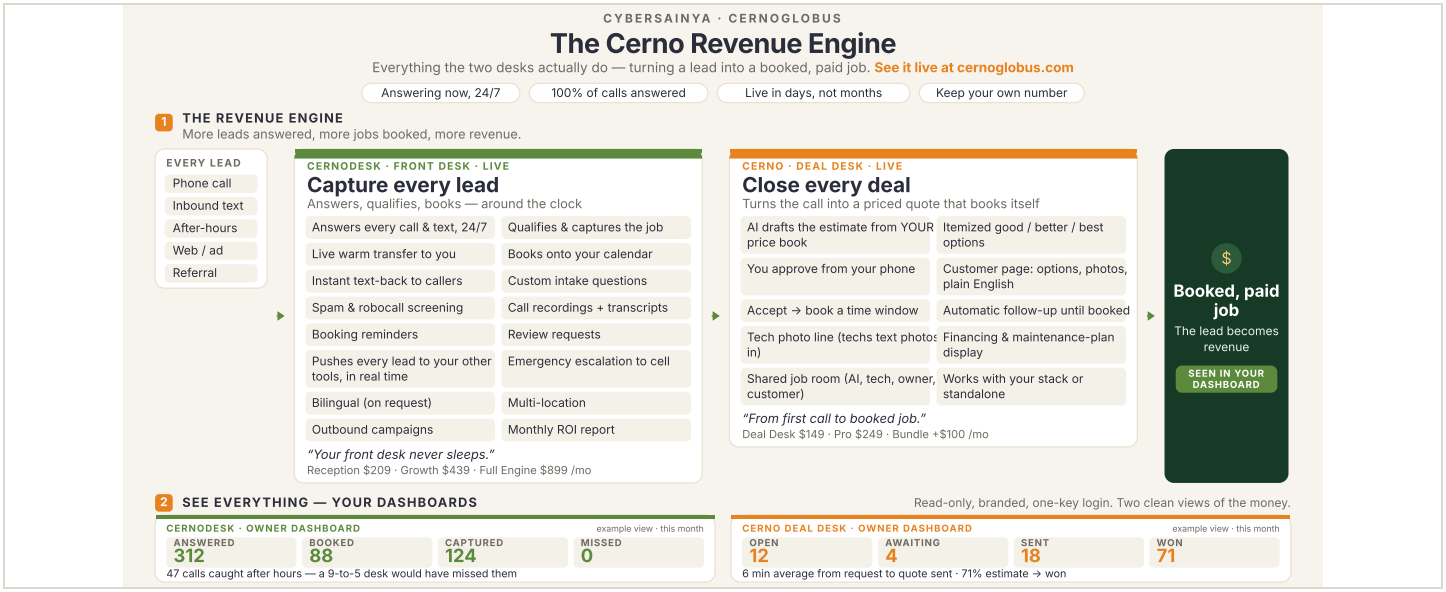
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern a home services operator. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A trade that emails estimates, service tickets and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



FREE FROM CERNOGLOBUS

Wary of AI? Start where it falls over.

Module 1 of **AI for Business Growth** is free to read — no signup, no card.

What AI is good for in a trade business, and where it breaks. Seven modules, $149. · cernoglobus.com/ai-for-business-growth

Questions? Reach out.
Corrections, tips, or something you want covered next.
info@cernoglobus.com

The Revenue Engine
See both desks running, and the pricing

AI for Business Growth
Module 1 free — no signup, no card

Subscribe
Get this brief every other Monday

CernoGlobus
Who publishes this brief, and what we build